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» HOKATO HOTOZHE SEMA

Category: Athletics (Men's Shot Put F57)

40-year-old Havildar Hokato Hotozhe Sema of the 9 Assam Regiment became the first athlete from Nagaland to win a Paralympic medal after securing bronze in the men's shot put F57 event with a personal best throw of 14.65 metres.

A landmine blast while on duty in Jammu and Kashmir in 2002 resulted in the amputation of Hokato's left leg below the knee, ending his dream of joining the Special Forces. Encouraged by his seniors, he began training in athletics, competing in the F57 category, which is for athletes with a limb deficiency, leg length difference, impaired muscle power, or impaired

range of movement.

In 2023, Hokato won a bronze medal at the Asian Para Games in Hangzhou and narrowly missed the podium at the 2024 World Championships before sealing his Paralympic medal in Paris.

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SHIV KUMAR PUSHPAKAR

» SIMRAN SHARMA

Category: Athletics (Women's 200m T12)

Simran Sharma clinched a bronze medal in the women's 200m T12 final at the Paris 2024 Paralympics by clocking a personal best time of 24.75 seconds, alongside her guide Abhay Singh. (The T12 class is for runners with visual impairments, hence athletes compete with a guide on the track.)

This medal came after the Ghaziabad-born athlete agonisingly missed out on a bronze medal in the 100m event.

Born prematurely at six and a half months, Simran was visually impaired and required six

months of incubator care. Inspired by her father, Manoj Sharma, she pursued sports and trained under Naik Gajendra Singh, whom she married in 2023.

Simran became the first Indian para-athlete to qualify for the Tokyo Paralympics but she did not get any medals. At the 2022 Asian Para Games in Hangzhou, she won two silver medals in the 100m and 200m T12 events. Earlier this year, she also claimed a gold medal at the World Para Athletics Championships in Kobe, Japan.